

SPONSORSHIP WITHIN A.A.'S THREE LEGACIES

The Three Legacies of Alcoholics Anonymous grew out of the individual and collective experience of A.A.'s early members as they struggled to gain, maintain and pass along the hard-won lessons of sobriety to other alcoholics. For these once-hopeless drinkers, the principles and the program of Alcoholics Anonymous provided the firm foundation for a new life based on the Twelve Steps, the Twelve Traditions and the Twelve Concepts. These principles continue to be vital foundations for countless alcoholics all over the world and in many languages. The Legacies of Recovery, Unity and Service — represented in the Steps, Traditions and Concepts — are interconnected and interdependent.

In meetings around the world, the metaphor of A.A. as a three-legged stool supported by the Three Legacies is often used. Remove one leg and the stool tips over. Without Recovery, as found in A.A.'s Twelve Steps, there would be no need for Unity. Without Unity, as supported by A.A.'s Twelve Traditions, groups would not survive, and there would be no need for Service. Without Service, as represented in A.A.'s Twelve Concepts, there would be no one available to carry the message, leaving Recovery unattainable to suffering alcoholics.

Recovery

The Twelve Steps provide the basis for recovery. First articulated in the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, the Steps were written by A.A. co-founder Bill W. based on spiritual principles and practices from the fields of religion, medicine and psychology.

Reflecting upon these inspirations, Bill wrote, "The Oxford Groups of that day threw heavy emphasis on personal work, one member with another. A.A.'s Twelfth Step had its origin in that vital practice. The moral backbone of the 'O.G.' was absolute honesty, absolute purity, absolute unselfishness, and absolute love. They also practiced a type of confession, which they called 'sharing'; the making of amends for harms done they called 'restitution.' They believed deeply in their 'quiet time,' a meditation practiced by groups and individuals alike, in which the guidance of God was sought for every detail of living, great or small." (*The Language of the Heart*, page 196)

Bill noted that Dr. Silkworth "contribute[d] a very great idea without which A.A. could never have succeeded. For years he had been proclaiming alcoholism an illness, an obsession of the mind coupled with an allergy of the body ... That's where medical science, personified by this benign little doctor, began to fit in. Held in the hands of one alcoholic talking to the next, this double-edged truth was a sledgehammer which could shatter the tough alcoholic's ego at depth and lay him wide open to the grace of God."

Bill also wrote about contributions from psychology. "William James did even more. Not only, he [James] said, could spiritual experiences make people saner, they could transform men and women so that they could do, feel, and believe what had hitherto been impossible to them."

Unity

The Twelve Traditions were hammered out on the anvil of A.A. experience and presented to the Fellowship by Bill W. in 1946 through a series of articles in the *AA Grapevine*. Based on the trial-and-error experiences of A.A.'s early groups, Bill W. set out to write down what was working in the Fellowship and what was not. Major questions about membership, money and the relationship of one group to another threatened to crowd out the early success members were having in getting and staying sober. Recognizing the importance of unity within the newly formed Fellowship, Bill noted at one point that if all the rules and requirements in effect in different groups had been active across the entire Fellowship at the same time no one, including himself, would have qualified for membership. Bill called those early members "children of chaos," noting however, that having "defiantly played with every brand of fire," as a Fellowship they had emerged unharmed and wiser.

So, how do we hold the Fellowship together? How do we arrange ourselves with sufficient — but not too much — organization? How do we relate ourselves rightly with the outside world? How do we identify and stick to our singular purpose — that of carrying the message to the still-suffering alcoholic?

In *Alcoholics Anonymous Comes of Age*, Bill addressed the purpose fulfilled by the Twelve Traditions. "The Twelve Traditions ... point straight at many of our individual defects. By implication they ask each of us to lay aside pride and resentment. They ask for personal as well as group sacrifice. They ask us never to use the A.A. name in any quest for personal power or distinction or money. The Traditions guarantee the equality of all members and the independence of all groups. They show how we may best relate ourselves to each other and to the world outside. They indicate how we can best function in harmony as a great whole. For the sake of the welfare of our entire society, the Traditions ask that every individual and every group and every area in A.A. shall lay aside all desires, ambitions, and untoward actions that could bring serious division among us or lose for us the confidence of the world at large. The Twelve Traditions of Alcoholics Anonymous symbolize the sacrificial character of our life together and they are the greatest force for unity that we know."

Service

On a fateful day in November 1934, Bill W.'s old friend Ebby T. visited him in Brooklyn with hopeful news about recovery — "one alcoholic had effectively carried the message to another." This fundamental transmission of hope, repeated when Bill W. met Dr. Bob on Mother's Day in 1935, put into motion a chain reaction of recovery that continues to this day.

Initially dependent on the ongoing guidance of the co-founders, a service structure slowly grew up around early A.A.s that came to include the General Service Office, the General Service Board and the General Service Conference, the designated successor to the co-founders.

In his article in *AA Grapevine* titled "A.A.'s Legacy of Service," Bill remarked on this development: "Until 1950, these overall services were the sole function of a few old-time A.A.s, several nonalcoholic friends, Doctor Bob, and me. For all the years of A.A.'s infancy, we old-timers had been the self-appointed trustees for Alcoholics Anonymous."

At this time, we realized that A.A. had grown up, that our Fellowship was ready and able to take these responsibilities from us ... This meant that we had to form a conference representing our membership which could meet yearly with our Board of Trustees in New York and thus assume direct responsibility for the guardianship of A.A. tradition and the direction of our principal service affairs."

With the growth of the Conference and the ongoing evolution of A.A., in 1962 Bill put forward the Twelve Concepts for World Service, a set of principles bringing form and clarity to A.A.'s world service structure. As noted in their introduction, "These Concepts ... aim to record the 'why' of our service structure in such a fashion that the highly valuable experience of the past, and the lessons we have drawn from that experience, can never be forgotten or lost."

Bill summed it up this way in *The Language of the Heart*: "By our Twelve Steps we have recovered, by our Twelve Traditions we have unified, and through A.A.'s Third Legacy — Service — we shall carry the A.A. message down through all the corridors of time to come."

Experience, Strength and Hope

The following are experiences of ten current A.A. members, all of whom have practiced the Three Legacies in their own lives thanks to their introduction through sponsorship. These stories are followed by a collection of brief reflections on topics related to the 36 principles contained in the Twelve Steps, Twelve Traditions and Twelve Concepts.

The journey from that day to this has been one of "buckling up." My first sponsor, Ruby, said I should get involved in service right away. I thought I was doing well enough just going to meetings, but one day in my second year of sobriety, my group asked me if I wanted to be the GSR (general service representative). I thought I had arrived! Well, I went to the district meeting and had a spiritual awakening. There was a whole other world outside my home group but intimately connected to it. It was there I learned about all the subcommittees and the myriad ways in which A.A. carries the message of recovery.

— Máire, Victoria BC

I intuitively knew I needed two things: a home group and a sponsor. Today, I call those my anchors in A.A., because without them I will drift. I started to do service in my home group. Shortly after I had a year of sobriety, someone asked me if I would like to be the alternate GSR. I did not know what that was, so they suggested I come with them to a district meeting. At that meeting, they read a section in the Service Manual written by nonalcoholic former chairperson of the General Service Board Bernard Smith called, "Why Do We Need a Conference?" I had a spiritual awakening while it was being read. It occurred to me that I had been away from A.A. for a little over a decade, between the time I stopped going to meetings and my time actively drinking. When I came back, A.A. was just as I remembered it — because while I was gone, someone was taking care of A.A. so it would be here when I came back.

— Joann, Petaluma CA

At first, I did not understand why I needed to incorporate the Traditions and Concepts into my life, but I do today, thanks to great sponsorship and my higher power. Through continued inventory and using the Traditions and Concepts to become a Three Legacy A.A. myself, I now sponsor people through all Three Legacies and can see how each of these principles correlates into my personal life. If my primary responsibility is to carry the message of A.A., then I sure better know what the message is in its entirety and not just one-third of it. The Three Legacies allow me to eat from the buffet of A.A. instead of just the salad bar.

— Kristen, Owensboro KY

My personal recovery experience has been shaped by a home group that emphasized all Three Legacies. So, I came to understand the Steps, Traditions and Concepts as much through observation of others adopting the principles as by any intellectual endeavor. But, having a demanding sponsor, who honestly read, studied and practiced — to the best of his ability — what he inherited in the Three Legacies made it much easier for me to avoid ignoring them through apathy or boredom.

I had a wonderful experience when I was invited to travel to a different country (Latvia) to present a Concepts workshop at their annual service convention. With attendees from several different countries — Latvia, Lithuania, Estonia and Russia, among others — we had to first vote on the language we would use in the workshop. It was unanimous to use Russian, even though there were some old political resentments that could have sprung from that. But it was the language that everyone could most commonly understand. All went happily forward in unity after the vote. It presented a wonderful example of Tradition Two, which is so important for much of the practice of our service business and Concepts.

— *Kenneth, Kennett Square, PA*

I got a service sponsor. She shared with me her experiences on the Traditions and Concepts, and, like my recovery sponsor, taught me the norms of these new meetings. My experience has shown me that all 36 principles dance beautifully together and expand the meanings of each for me. As my world gets bigger, Traditions and Concepts help me to continue to let God into new areas of my life.

— *Melissa, Sound Beach, NY*

A.A. offers us three elegant legacies: the Steps and our recovery, the Traditions and Fellowship, and the service Concepts and world service structure. When I participate in all of these, they create a sort of gymnasium in which I can safely practice being the person I'd like to be, in mutual support with others who understand. In recovery, unity and service I've learned to show up, make reasonable commitments, engender trust, stay on topic, speak my truth clearly, tell fact from opinion, listen as if I have not already decided, converse with anyone, criticize less, appreciate more, trust the group, lead when needed, and value our collective success more than any lesser prize including my own comfort or prestige. That is not who I was, but with practice it has spread through my family life, work life, and civic and social life, to my great relief and joy.

— *Jim, Mountain View, CA*

Some brief reflections on topics related to the principles contained in the Twelve Steps, Twelve Traditions and Twelve Concepts.

Practical principles: "In my mind the experience of the Three Legacies is like making glass. The needed ingredients are placed in the crucible (the Fellowship of A.A.), then both pressure and heat are applied (working through each of the principles underlying our 36 statements of practice), and the final result is something that can be shaped into the object that is needed. It is clear and almost completely transparent — but, oh! So very useful!"

— *Dennis, Farmington, MN*

A.A. membership: "Fortunately for me, those who came before me understood the Third Tradition: 'The only requirement for A.A. membership is a desire to stop drinking.' They did not pass judgment on whether or not my desire was good enough; they just told me to 'keep coming back.' As I began to dry out, I thought maybe I should treat those who came after me with the same openness. Today I try to practice the Third Tradition with the same enthusiasm I believe Bill W. and Dr. Bob had for an open-door policy in A.A. I like to tell new people, 'You are a member when you say you are a member.'"

— *Jimmy, Peculiar, MO*

Right of decision: "Concept III is easy to understand — with each service position within A.A., we have a right of decision. However, an important aspect of this both in A.A. and the wider world is to always do our best to seek out and consult with those who will be impacted by our

choices and decisions. And this weaves itself right into Tradition Four. We can sometimes be so quick to defend our autonomy and our 'right' to make decisions, giving no thought to how those decisions might have serious consequences for others."

— Annemarie, Taunton, MA

Carrying the message: "My work in Alcoholics Anonymous is directly related to carrying the message to the still-suffering alcoholic, including the ones currently in my family and the ones I've yet to meet. Learning to carry the message within the Traditions of Alcoholics Anonymous enables me to be more effective and protects A.A. from outside interference. Learning to understand the Service Manual and apply the Concepts to any 'big ideas' I might have has taught me valuable lessons in humility."

— Roxane, Valley Center, CA

Spiritual growth: "When I was three weeks sober, I went to my first Area Assembly — not to be of service, but because I was crazy and knew I should not spend much time alone and unsupervised. I started going to district meetings within my first month of sobriety, and, in fact, went to several before someone asked me if I had a service position, which I did not. So, I was asked to be the scribe. As the years progressed and my life blossomed with a career, a wife, kids and many other wonderful events, I progressed down the triangle. By the time I was a DCM, at about five years of sobriety, I became aware of how big a part general service was playing in my spiritual growth. My life today is better than it's ever been, and I believe that is because I have availed myself of everything that A.A. has to offer, not just the parts I liked."

— Keith, Flower Mound, TX

Where to find A.A.

There are A.A. groups in large cities, rural areas and villages throughout the world. These resources can help direct you to a meeting in your community:

- Many A.A. intergroup or central offices have websites where information about local A.A. meetings can be found, and almost anywhere in the United States or Canada you can use the "A.A. Near You" section on the A.A. website: www.aa.org.
- You can also find a meeting by downloading the Meeting Guide app at no cost on your smartphone.
- Additionally, information about local meetings can often be obtained from healthcare workers, faith leaders, media outlets, hospitals and alcoholism facilities that are familiar with our program.

Each A.A. group endeavors to provide a safe meeting place for all attendees and to encourage a secure and nurturing environment. In A.A., the shared experience, strength and hope of sober alcoholics is the lifeline to sobriety; our common suffering and our common solution transcend most difficulties, helping us to create the conditions in which to carry A.A.'s message of hope and recovery to the still-suffering alcoholic.

If you cannot locate a group in your area, please contact the A.A. General Service Office, Box 459, Grand Central Station, New York, NY 10163, (212) 870-3400, www.aa.org. They will put you in touch with the group nearest you.